



Report Date: April 2, 2026

VanRIMS No.: 08-3000-30

[Submit comments to the Board](#)

TO: Park Board Chair and Commissioners
FROM: Director, Park Planning and Development
SUBJECT: Electric Commuter Ferry Service Adjacent Harbour Green Park

RECOMMENDATIONS

- A. THAT the Vancouver Park Board endorse the concept of changes to Harbour Green Dock to enable a commercial electric foot passenger ferry service to operate at the site while continuing to provide a public amenity for recreational watercraft moorage and a public viewing platform;
- B. THAT the Vancouver Park Board indicate their support for City staff to negotiate, to the satisfaction of the City Engineer and the City's Director of Legal Services, and in consultation with the Park Board's General Manager, and enter into an agreement with CIRQL Ferries Incorporated to deliver the services and amenities described above, subject to the agreement being within the parameters outlined in this report; and
- C. FURTHER THAT, subject to the execution of the agreement described in Recommendation B, the Vancouver Park Board direct staff to prepare a Memorandum of Understanding with City departments confirming that ownership, operation, and maintenance responsibilities for Harbour Green Dock and supporting infrastructure shall henceforth be held by Engineering Services, reflecting the transportation-primary focus of the amenity and the City's water lot tenure.

PURPOSE AND SUMMARY

This report provides an update on a proposal by CIRQL Ferries Incorporated (CIRQL Ferries) to establish an electric passenger ferry service connecting downtown Vancouver with Bowen Island and Gibsons, and the associated physical and operational changes to Harbour Green Dock that would enable the site to become the Vancouver landing location for the service while continuing to provide a public amenity for recreational watercraft moorage and a public viewing platform. The realization of this opportunity will require Park Board and Council direction for City staff to negotiate and enter into an agreement with the proponent, in consultation with the Park Board's General Manager and in compliance with City procurement policy. If the agreement is executed, operation and maintenance responsibilities for Harbour Green Dock and supporting infrastructure will be transferred to Engineering Services, reflecting the transportation-primary focus of the amenity and the City's water lot tenure.

BOARD AUTHORITY / PREVIOUS DECISIONS

- Harbour Green Park is a park under the care, custody and management of the Park Board (not a designated temporary or permanent park)
- The existing dock and floating walkway marine structures are located within a City-owned water lot, dedicated as roadway.
- The adjacent seawall and associated seawall pathway are located within dedicated roadway and under jurisdiction of City Engineering Services.
- At Park Board meeting of [April 15, 2019](#), the Board unanimously supported the staff recommendations contained within the report dated [April 5, 2019](#).
- In response to Recommendation B of the April 15, 2019, Decision, staff provided a report back to the Park Board via a Board Briefing Memo dated [February 14, 2020](#).
- Park Board Member's Motion of February 24, 2025: [Support for Sustainable Transportation](#)

CONTEXT AND BACKGROUND

Harbour Green Dock is located within the Coal Harbour Official Development Plan (ODP) area. The ODP identifies the waterfront as a publicly accessible area that includes a continuous waterfront walkway, transient moorage, and marine activity, including potential water transportation uses such as ferry or water taxi services. The existing dock and its potential use for a passenger ferry service are consistent with these policy directions.



Figure 1: Existing Harbour Green Dock

The dock is situated within a City-owned water lot adjacent to the seawall and Harbour Green Park. The floating dock and walkway have historically been operated and maintained by the Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation.

Harbour Green Dock was built in 2003 by the developer of the Coal Harbour development, through developer-delivery agreements, to provide a pedestrian promenade close to the water and to allow for temporary daytime moorage by light pleasure watercrafts. Before the end of construction, the dock required a retrofit to reduce excessive vertical movement of the floats. Further repairs were undertaken soon after in 2005, and on multiple occasions since then, including a significant repair that involved closure of the dock from 2018 to 2023. Further damage has necessitated periodic closures in 2024 and 2025. The frequent maintenance issues are related to the dock's original design, the particular wave conditions of the site, and damage caused by unauthorized moorage of vessels exceeding the dock's design specifications.

Following Park Board [direction](#) of April 15, 2019, Park Board staff provided a report back via Board Briefing [Memo](#), advising that inter-regional transportation connections would require a purpose-built facility, indicating that the current dock is inadequate to support those services.

Following Park Board [direction](#) on February 24, 2025, and Council [direction](#) on March 12, 2025, Park Board and City staff received a proposal from CIRQL Ferries to operate an electric ferry service and have been working with the proponent to review the feasibility of accommodating an electric passenger ferry service at a reconfigured and renewed Harbour Green Dock. The proposed service would connect downtown Vancouver with Bowen Island and the Sunshine Coast (Gibsons).

DISCUSSION

Policy Alignment

In addition to the ODP alignment and the Park Board and Council directions referenced above, The City of Vancouver's [Transportation 2040 Plan](#) recommends support to increase water-based transit in Burrard Inlet and other water bodies. As described below, the proposed service model offers an opportunity to align with [VanPlay](#) (2019/2020): The Park Board's Parks and Recreation Services Master Plan, Goal 1: to grow and renew assets.

Technical Feasibility

Staff have completed a preliminary review of the proposed location and conceptual dock configurations prepared the proponent's consultant team. A preferred concept has been identified that includes a 'charge barge' for the CIRQL Ferries vessels, a publicly accessible viewing platform and dock for short-term recreational moorage. Conceptual digital renderings are shown in Appendix A. The concept supports accessible access to each of the amenities, integrates with existing waterfront uses, and maintains the necessary separation between ferry operations, governed by Transport Canada, and public use areas.

The specific configuration of the dock, including the extent of reuse or replacement of existing infrastructure, will be further refined through detailed design as the project progresses. Regulatory reviews and approvals will be completed. Electrical and utility servicing work is underway with BC Hydro and City staff. The project would likely require new electrical transformer infrastructure and trenching of new utilities through Harbour Green Park. Park Board staff can provide review and input to minimize disruption to park amenities associated with the installation and servicing of these utilities. Environmental impacts to the marine habitat will be incorporated through design, environmental management plans, and applicable regulations and permitting.

Agreement Framework

If supported by Park Board decision, City staff will seek Council authorization to negotiate an agreement with CIRQL Ferries.

Based on discussions to date, the agreement is anticipated to include the following considerations:

- Proponent responsibility for the design, construction, and delivery of all required infrastructure, including dock structures, charge barge, and supporting utilities
- Proponent responsibility for obtaining all required permits, approvals, and regulatory authorizations
- Proponent responsibility for ongoing operations and maintenance of ferry-related infrastructure within the licensed operational area
- A clearly defined licensed area, with exclusive use limited to ferry operations, and continued provision of public amenities including a floating viewing platform and short-term recreational moorage within a separate area
- Operating hours aligned with ferry service schedules, while maintaining appropriate public access and considering seasonal variations in recreational use
- A passenger-based revenue model payable to the City on an annual basis
- A service agreement term anticipated to be approximately 10 years, with potential extension options, subject to performance and agreement conditions
- Additional provisions as required and all to the satisfaction of the City Engineer, the City's Director of Legal Services, and in consultation with the Park Board's General Manager

First Nations Engagement

Consistent with Council's direction on March 12, 2025 to consult with the Musqueam, Squamish and Tsleil-Waututh Nations, staff have provided notifications to the local Nations regarding the City's role in this project and the work underway.

Staff have been informed that CIRQL Ferries has also engaged with Musqueam, Squamish and Tsleil-Waututh Nations regarding the proposed service. As part of the proposed agreement, the City intends to include a clause requiring the proponent to continue engagement with Nations as the project advances.

Public and Interest Holder Engagement

CIRQL Ferries has completed market research confirming demand for their proposed service. Pending Council approval to proceed with agreement negotiations, the City will provide notice to impacted residents, businesses and interest holders in the Coal Harbour area.

FINANCIAL CONSIDERATIONS

The proposed approach does not require new funding from the City. All capital costs associated with the design, construction, and implementation of the ferry infrastructure, including dock structures, public viewing platform, recreational boating features, charge barge, and electrical

servicing, will be the responsibility of CIRQL Ferries. The City will receive a share of revenues from the ferry service, which may be used in part to offset the in-kind operational support from the City such as emergency services and bylaw enforcement.

Harbour Green Dock has required ongoing maintenance and periodic repairs to sustain operations. In the absence of this project, the Park Board would continue to incur increasing costs to maintain and replace the existing public dock infrastructure over time. The proposed approach provides an opportunity to renew the public dock infrastructure at no cost to the city.

OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

Transfer of Asset to City Engineering Services

Although operation and maintenance of Harbour Green Dock has recently been a responsibility of the Park Board, the asset and water lot are owned by the City and management of marine structures that support transportation initiatives is typically a responsibility of City Engineering Services. Staff recommend that, subject to the realization of the proposed ferry initiative, the transfer of operating and maintenance responsibilities for this asset be formalized through an inter-departmental Memorandum of Understanding. The City may in turn assign some responsibilities to the ferry service proponent, as discussed in this report.

Legal Implications

The recommendations in this report require negotiation and execution of an agreement between the City, in consultation with the Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation, and CIRQL Ferries to authorize the use and occupation of City-owned lot (designated as road) for ferry operations at Harbour Green Dock.

The agreement will address key legal considerations including allocation of responsibilities for design, construction, operations and maintenance, insurance and indemnification provisions, and compliance with applicable laws, bylaws, and regulatory requirements. The procurement approach will be undertaken in accordance with the City's procurement policies. The final form of agreement will be subject to review and approval by the Director of Legal Services prior to execution.

CONCLUSION AND NEXT STEPS

The proposed replacement of Harbour Green dock with an electric passenger ferry service facility represents an opportunity to enhance regional connectivity while supporting low-emission transportation, improved public access and renewed recreational boat moorage on the waterfront via investment from the proponent. Preliminary technical review indicates that a reconfigured and renewed Harbour Green Dock can accommodate the proposed services.

With the Park Board's approval, City staff can seek direction from Council to negotiate and enter into an agreement with the proponent. Subject to successful negotiations and procurement process, the project would advance to detailed design, regulatory approvals, and potential implementation.

APPENDIX A

CONCEPTUAL RENDERINGS



Figure 2: Conceptual Rendering – Aerial View

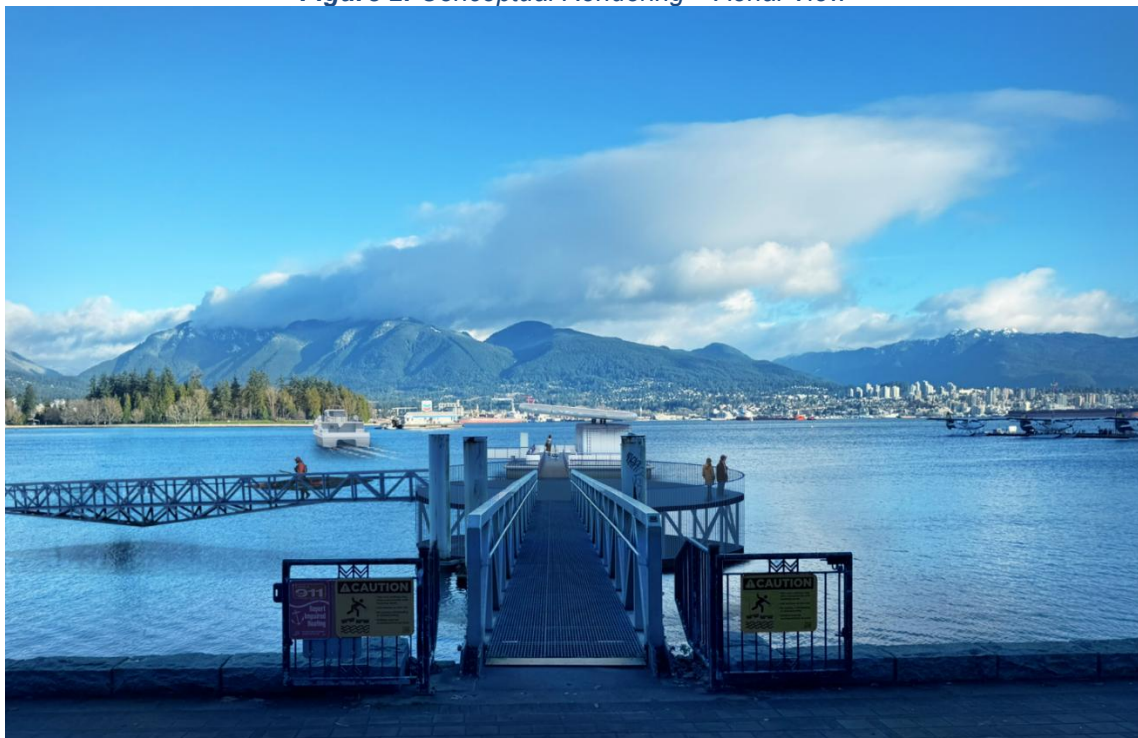


Figure 3: Conceptual Rendering – View from Dock Entrance



Figure 4: Conceptual Rendering – View from the east of Harbour Green Dock